

What else to watch: *How to Be Loved* (1963) ■ *The Army of Shadows* (1969) ■ *The Birch Wood* (1970) ■ *The Promised Land* (1975) ■ *Man of Marble* (1977) ■ *Rough Treatment* (1978) ■ *Man of Iron* (1981) ■ *A Love in Germany* (1983) ■ *Katyn* (2007)



Andrzej Wajda Director

Born in Poland in 1926, Andrzej Wajda became one of his country's most celebrated filmmakers. He lived through the German occupation of Europe, which shaped most of his work. A key figure of the "Polish Film School," he brought a fresh air of neorealism to his depictions of the men and women who

endured the war, and his movies play an enormously important part in understanding what happened to Poland—and the world—in the last century.

Key movies

1957 *Kanal*
1958 *Ashes and Diamonds*
1975 *The Promised Land*
1977 *Man of Marble*

Polish Resistance fighters were crushed by the German army. Third was *Ashes and Diamonds*, an angry, melancholy movie set during the chaos of the German occupation's aftermath, once the dust of the liberation had begun to settle.

Questioning the cause

Ashes and Diamonds focuses on Maciek (Zbigniew Cybulski), a young soldier in Poland's right-wing Nationalist Army who fought in the uprising against the Nazis with the goal of establishing Polish sovereignty. As the Soviet Union takes control, Maciek is ordered to assassinate a new Communist official, but he has second thoughts about waging a doomed war against the incoming left-wing administration. He bungles the murder, killing two bystanders.

Torn between his conscience and loyalty to the cause for which he fought in the war, Maciek embarks on a second half-hearted attempt at

the killing. This time he is waylaid when he falls in love with Krystyna (Ewa Krzyzewska), who works at the hotel in which his target is a guest. She confuses him further, forcing him to question the beliefs that have driven him for as long as he can

remember. Looking up at the sky, Maciek sees fireworks exploding in the darkness. The fireworks—glittering diamonds rising from the ashes of Warsaw—announce Germany's surrender and the end of war. Yet Wajda's trademark note of uncertainty hangs in the air: it's the end of an era for Poland, but what will the future bring?

Dubious dawn

"What did you do during the uprising?" is a question that echoed around daily lives in Poland for decades after the war. In his portrait of one man's fractured identity, Wajda constantly draws our attention to broken glass and splintered buildings. This sense of fracture runs through the country, and cannot be ignored. ■

“You know not if flames bring freedom or death.”

Krystyna / *Ashes and Diamonds*



In the ruins of a bombed-out church, Maciek reflects on his equally battered ideals. It is here that Krystyna finds an inscription of the poem from which the movie takes its name.